

Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn Statements (internal, RU only)

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1 Background Information

Hopefully, I am just overthinking, and it will be quick and easy, but just in case I provide here extra background information that should be helpful if the case gets difficult.

My home department, public policy and administration (DPPA), is a peculiar department. One peculiarity is emphasis on activism, community engagement, and service. Rutgers-Camden is R-2 High Research Activity institution—we should be mostly about research, say about 60% research, 25% teaching, 15% service, but DPPA is quite the opposite: about 60% activism/civic engagement/service,

20% teaching, and 20% research.¹ Another peculiarity is that there are some very strong personalities. Opinions are equally strong—I pre-emptively respond to those in Appendix. All I am asking for is a fair evaluation based on objective evidence. For instance, see evidence of my service in CV. Also note that I am facing a cross-department friction: I led the creation of, I support, and teach in Data Science program, and I serve on dissertation committees in Prevention Science program—both programs are outside of DPPA—details are in Appendix: teaching and service sections.

My biggest worry is that DPPA might have solicited external letters from outside of my field. There are no DPPA faculty in happiness research—but there are some who like to have opinions about it. See what the experts in happiness research say—these should be hopefully the external letters.

2 Research

I am in the field of social indicators, quality of life, wellbeing, and life satisfaction. The main journals are *Applied Research in Quality of Life* (ARIQ) and *Social Indicators Research* (SIR).² The main academic/professional organization is International Society for Quality-of-Life Studies (ISQOLS). My field is thinner on theory than other social science, (post-)positivist, and quantitative—about patterns, relationships, and effects—but rather correlational than causal. (Quasi-)experiments are very rare, and there are more descriptions and visualizations than economics and statistics. My field is somewhere between geography, sociology, psychology, and philosophy.³

All research is (supposed to be) new in some sense, but my research is more original/innovative than most. Many contribute only incrementally, say by slightly improving a model, adding an interaction or instrumental variables. My contribution is new ideas—human creativity is important in current AI age. I have creative ideas, and then able to find the right data to test them. I was the first to look at several relationships:⁴ energy use→happiness (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Altman 2019), social v individual religiosity→happiness across countries (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2010) and →trust in the US (Valente and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2021), religiosity→creativity across space (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015b), and person v society level politics→happiness (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2014).

My main area of research has been urban-rural happiness gradient, a term coined in my early paper on the topic: “An urban-rural happiness gradient” (Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2011). This line of research is not entirely new—it has been studied in a quantitative fashion in a limited way in the 70s and philosophically since antiquity—but mine are the first studies in modern times.⁵ And I have a related line of research looking at livability of places: Okulicz-Kozaryn (2013), Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2019a).

My urban-rural happiness gradient research includes careful gradient elaboration (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2017) and theory-rich Okulicz-Kozaryn and Mazelis (2018). As the research has matured, I added: generational differences (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2019b), adolescence (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2020), panel data (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023), elaborated happiness measurement (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2024), and Covid19’s effect (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2026). Finally, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021) shows that urban unhappiness is common across countries.

I work with students to explore the gradient further: examined population change instead of level (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2024), and turned to non-WEIRD (Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic) societies: India (Deb and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023), Egypt (Mikhaeil et al. 2024), and Colombia (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2026).

I am at the forefront of the urban-rural happiness debate.⁶ Some may argue that happiness has little to do with public policy and

¹This is even more problematic when there are graduate students especially PhDs, as it is the case in DPPA—how can we teach and mentor them to do research, if we don’t do research ourselves?

²Journal of Happiness Studies has shifted towards positive psychology and happiness economics. ARIQ is the flagship journal of ISQOLS.

³Geography is a notable part of it—my research intersects with geography: regions, and especially urban-rural gradient. This is a subjective description of the field, or rather sub-field, and this is where I fit. There are other sub-fields, notably positive psychology and happiness economics—they are related but different in important ways. My field is well described by its pioneer, Alex Michalos: Michalos (2014b,a).

⁴In quantitative way, focusing on and elaborating the relationship (not just listing among others or controlling for it). You will see in my many papers that the idea is indeed the first of its kind—nobody has looked at the relationship before in this way.

⁵There is a 30-40 year generational gap between mostly 70s and very few in early 80s versus my first study in 2009.

⁶For instance see the discussion in framing essay IV in Edited by Pia Heike Johansen and Fisker (2022). Likewise the literature has picked on “energy-happiness paradox”—the term that I have coined (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Altman 2019), for instance see: Nasrudin et al. (2022), Park et al. (2025), Bakehe

administration—nothing further from the truth⁷

Near-future trajectory remains similar: mostly urban-rural happiness gradient and regional happiness, adding Latin American focus (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Martinez 2025). I plan to spend more time on grant writing to grow my research group, hire students and post-docs, and do course buy-outs.⁸

Since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, I have published 37 peer-reviewed articles, including 7 in *Cities*, a journal with impact factor (IF)=8.1, higher than the top journal in public administration in the US,⁹ *Public Administration Review* with IF=7.2.¹⁰ Since 2017 I have also published 4 articles in *Social Indicators Research*, and 9 in *Applied Research in Quality of Life*, both leading/main journals in my field. I am also collegial and collaborative—I've coauthored with over 20 authors (Scopus), and my citations more than tripled (Scopus) or more than doubled (Google Scholar) since 2017. See details and more metrics in Appendix: "Scientometrics" section.

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et al. (2026), Du and Zhang (2025).

⁷See Diener (2009) and my own Okulicz-Kozaryn (2016). Likewise, there are clear policy implications of my work, for instance see (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015a, Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2014, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Golden 2017). My numerous *Cities* papers have dedicated takeaways for policy/practice section, e.g., see recent (Mikhael et al. 2024, Deb and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2022), and even if the section is missing, there are still policy implications, e.g., Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021).

⁸My past external funding includes the prestigious Polish National Science Foundation (PI), equivalent of the US Natl Science Foundation. And currently, I spend more time on http://pivot.proquest.com/funding_opps/ and collaborate with Todd Regn (RU-Camden grant expert) on grant ideas.

⁹I am in a department of public policy and administration in the US.

¹⁰<https://www.scimagojr.com/journalsearch.php?q=16956&tip=sid> and <https://www.scimagojr.com/journalsearch.php?q=17167&tip=sid>

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3 Teaching

Something I have dreaded as a student, and promised myself I won't do on the other side as an instructor. Style over substance: prioritizing appearance, aesthetics, and presentation over actual quality, meaning, and functionality—it looks and sounds impressive but lacks value, real utility—just like much of social science prose.¹¹ Instruction is unnecessarily fluffy and ornamented, often grandiose as if the goal is to put student in a sense of awe. The problem seems especially acute in political science and public policy and administration.

Now as an instructor I skip the fluff and cut to the chase—convey practical information efficiently. Usefulness/utility is the key. Learning by doing, no memorizing—for instance, students bring their own data and we apply skills and tools learned in the class to the data, no exams. When I was a student I was forced to memorize theory and formulas and read hundreds of pages of formal texts. But I wasn't taught how to use the skills and the tools. I condense the material, make it relevant, maximize utility/usefulness with minimum effort, focus on what's most important in most accessible practical hands on way.

Students appreciate my teaching style, e.g., "left a lasting impression on me and I appreciated your approach and teaching style" and "Your passion for education has inspired and impacted me in so many ways. Your commitment to helping your students grow and learn is truly admirable. Thank you for all that you do!"

I decrease instruction and increase interaction: discussions, presentations, "flip the class,"¹² and extra labs in addition to the class. Such interactive social approach seems even more important in current reality: short attention span, information overload, AI, and

¹¹See <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11192-012-0937-9>.

¹²Work on projects and homework collaboratively in class as opposed to home as done traditionally.

mental health problems. We need to connect, be at ease, have good energy, and even some fun in class—it shouldn't be tedious and gruesome, at least not all of it.

It is not watering down the curriculum. I provide plenty of extra/bonus materials so that it is customized to a student, doesn't overwhelm with unnecessary stuff, but provides enough depth and individual learning path. Pleasant learning experience matters, but so do outcomes.

I want my teaching to produce results. Learning (motivation, too) is the direct result. But then comes transfer of knowledge, ability to apply that learned information. We need results either in academia or outside of it.

I have supervised 9 dissertations (5 in-progress). Four PhDs have graduated, and all have a job. One is at SIPRI (Stockholm International Peace Research Institute), a think-tank ranked 11th or 31st worldwide.¹³ Another one at Virginia Tech and the other 2 were employed at Rutgers when graduated. My students publish. Since 2020, we have published 10 peer-reviewed papers with my students in good journals including 3 in top ranked *Cities* with Impact Factor of 8.1.

One highlight is that the skills learned in the classes not only work in the academic research, but also in the real world: "The classes I took with you are helping not only my scholarship, but my day job [...] I greatly appreciate it." and "subject: Received a Job Offer [...] I would like to thank you for all of the guidance and knowledge during all of your data-related courses the past several semesters to help me get to the point I am at today." and "since graduating I have continued to pursue more projects in the coding world. Some analysis projects, business models, [...] I appreciate all the help and motivation you gave me in class as it helped me to really see what I can come up with from all of the useful tools, how to plan and build on projects, and skills gained from having you as my professor."

I try to guide students individually, in the grand scheme of things, teaching is about helping students become who they are, and everyone is little different. This is another reason for forcing less required material and making more available as bonus/extra for self-actualization. I make sure I am available and approachable for students spending extra time outside of classroom: working on papers, being accessible via zoom and in person, including when on sabbatical.¹⁴

A final point on my teaching philosophy. I support public/civic service/engagement in my teaching. All my classes encourage (but not force) and give extra credit for it. And I support students even after the class in their civic endeavors—see service section. But this is not activism, it is evidence based, data driven analysis and problem-solving. It is rather positivistic "what is," than normative "what should be,"¹⁵ I support in my teaching old fashioned critical thinking, and I don't believe classroom is a place for political indoctrination of the students. I'm (post-)positivist in my teaching—I encourage students to try to get closer to the objective truth through evidence and data. Activism and political action are better left to politicians.

Please also look at my teaching appendix in this document—it serves as my teaching portfolio and there are many important details there. I concluded my teaching philosophy, now turning to technicalities. One highlight is unusually heavy curriculum development. Since coming to Rutgers-Camden in 2012, I have taught over 10 different classes, developed from scratch most of them, including 3 courses in 2023 for our new data science program. I am updating my teaching materials each time I teach a class. In addition, I am working on my teaching materials relatively continuously (still I do take long breaks for research only). The point is that I put much effort into teaching and revise, update, upgrade, extend, etc the teaching materials frequently—for instance my visualization class has been updated 200 times over past 3 years: <https://github.com/theaok/vis/commits/main/>.

I teach, mentor, and support students from different programs. In my home department of public policy and administration (PPA), I teach regularly in Masters of Public Administration (MPA) and MS and PhD in Public Affairs, but I also teach regularly students from MS in Data science in my always cross listed PPA courses. Usually there are also few PhDs from Prevention Science, and occasionally

¹³<https://thinktankalert.com/rankings> and <https://guides.library.upenn.edu/c.php?g=1035991&p=7509972>

¹⁴Now in Spring 2026 I am on sabbatical, but I still have 4 students enrolled in my dissertation hours, and I work with other students on papers informally.

¹⁵Similar to Network of Schools of Public Policy, Affairs, and Administration (NASPAA) competency: "to analyze, synthesize, think critically, solve problems and make decisions." Invariably, some activism creeps in many student projects—the challenge is to unlearn what students "learn" in some other classes. And some forms of activism as in "policy implications" may be useful as long as it is kept to the minimum and follows from actual research and is evidence based.

from other departments such as Psychology, and Criminology and Sociology.

I strive to improve my teaching: I just attended cybersecurity trainings,¹⁶ and attended Instructional Design and Technology (IDT) workshop on "Crafting the Learner-Centered Syllabus" in 2024. And I quite regularly read on teaching and mentoring advice, tips and tricks on [nature.com](https://www.nature.com), [chronicle.com](https://www.chronicle.com), and [insidehighered.com](https://www.insidehighered.com).

My teaching strength and preference is data science classes, but also happiness class that aligns with my research. I have been also developing a new class "social indicators" that would be broader than just happiness and include topics such as trust, freedom, and meaning. This would also align with my editorial position at Social Indicators Research journal.

I am interested in teaching short courses / microcredentials. I have already taught a short GIS course¹⁷ twice, informally, for my colleagues from the department and other faculty from Arts and Sciences, and for Walter Rand Institute. But I would like to teach more often and other short courses. There is an initiative to create Microcredentials and Digital Badges—I would like to participate in it.

I am 2025 recipient of department's Jay A Sigler award for "outstanding service and dedication to students" (awarded by students); the plaque says "this award is given to the faculty member who exhibits a commitment to student's academic development and personal growth."

4 Service

My service mostly builds on and derives from my main focus and strength, research. I provide such service in two main ways: 1) to the profession/scholarly field, and 2) to students.

I review papers for journals, 4-5/mo or 48-60/year as of May 2026, including the top journals such as Journal of Personality and Social Psychology and Public Administration Review (see CV for details). Reviewing is an essential foundation of scholarly fields, and increasingly in short supply—something I can attest to as a journal editor. Since January 2024, I co-edit Social Indicators Research, the leading journal in my field of quality of life and wellbeing. My editorial philosophy is to be mentor and helper, not just gate-keeper—for instance, I am often in favor of revision prior to external review (instead of desk-reject), and I try to guide the authors, especially the junior ones.¹⁸

My research-oriented service over past 6 years 2020-2026 to students is: published 10 peer-reviewed articles with students as co-authors, supervised 9 dissertations (4 graduated; 5 in-progress), served on 6 dissertation committees, supervised 6 data science master theses, served on 2 master thesis committees in other social science, and supervised 15 independent studies. I have also led brown bag seminars and organized a workshop on academic publishing.

And I am very excited about bringing to campus an award winning¹⁹ junior professor from Germany as a visiting scholar for 2 months in Fall 2026: Leonie C. Steckermeier. Leonie is a productive scholar already benefiting 2 of our doctoral students—we have monthly or so zoom meetings where we are already working on papers.

I contribute service to the campus and department. Over 2018-2022 I have lead the development of a new MS in data science and associated certificate program. This was a substantial undertaking and also somewhat challenging as the newly created programs are located outside of my home department. I have been serving since 2022 as a director for data science certificate.²⁰ I am currently

¹⁶2026 KnowBe4 Security Awareness Training, Cybersecurity Essentials: Secure Passwords, and Introduction to IT Security Policies—these enhance my classroom teaching—most of my courses involve computer coding or data science—cybersecurity matters more there than in usual social science courses.

¹⁷<https://theaok.github.io/shortGIS/>

¹⁸I am grateful to the editor of Journal of Applied Psychology who has guided me when I was a junior author.

¹⁹Publications: <https://scholar.google.com/citations?user=xjkPIhwAAAAJ&hl=de>. Awards: ISQOLS Prize for the Best Dissertation on Quality of Life, Well being, and Happiness, 2nd prize, 2023; Best PhD Dissertation of the Faculty of Human Sciences, Dissertation Award of the Otto von Guericke University Magdeburg for outstanding research achievements in the context of the dissertation, 2022; Second prize of the Fritz Thyssen Foundation for the best social science paper in German for the article "Eine Krise der sozialen Anerkennung? Ergebnisse einer Bevölkerungsbefragung zu Alltagserfahrungen der Wert- und Geringschätzung in Deutschland.", 2019

²⁰See certificates at the bottom of the page: <https://graduateschool1.camden.rutgers.edu/graduate-programs>

supervising 2 courtesy appointments as volunteer researchers in the department—they work with me on research but also helped students in my class. I frequently serve as either ad hoc chair or member on Advancement and Promotions (A&P) committee. I find this service fulfilling. I contribute to promoting quality faculty in our social sciences and I learn about my colleagues. Other committee service is enumerated in the CV.

While research-oriented service is my strength and passion, and usual campus and departmental service is my duty, I am also mindful of Rutgers-Camden public/community service/engagement mission. I agree that as a public university, we also need to engage with and provide service to the public and community. I have assisted a number of Rutgers-Camden students in their community projects over past 5 years serving as a faculty advisor for, for instance: Olorunfunmi Adebajo's internship at the Camden County Community Development Office's Homelessness Assistance Unit,²¹ Marlo Rossi's project at Walter Rand Institute and other projects on abortion,²² and Ojobo Agbo Eje: "Camden Health Equity Data Visualization Initiative."²³

New Jersey first, but I have been civically engaged outside of the Garden State as well. For instance, I have used my data management skills to assist with data collection and management for Ohio Business Round Table, and Michigan Economic Competitiveness Study.

In the ideal world, I would like to continue with research-oriented service. In particular, I would like to increase my research group²⁴ and co-author more with students, and ideally postdocs. Chairing dissertations and leading independent studies would be also my strength and preference. I'm happy to take on more administrative duties such as editing another journal or being a graduate director for our PhD program.

5 Appendix

5.1 Research

5.1.1 My research in DPPA

I was asked not to compare to specific persons and not to be personal, so no names, just overall department stats.

Quantity of research output is measured at researchwithrutgers.com²⁵—both at research units/department level and employee level. The department (research unit: Graduate School, Camden: Public Policy and Administration) has 10 employees.²⁶ Over the years 2019-2022²⁷ the 10 employees of the department have produced 37 research outputs,²⁸ out of which 17 were mine,²⁹ i.e., I have produced about half of the 10 person unit's output.³⁰

2023-May 2026, the department has produced 33 outputs, out of which 13 are mine—I have been burdened with unfair amount of service over past 3 years, but still I have produced 40% of the department's output.

Visibility (and arguably quality and competitiveness) of the research output can be measured as Impact Factor (IF). As far as I can tell from researchwithrutgers.com or scopus.com: 80% of the department does not publish in high impact journals consistently. Since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, I have published 37 peer-reviewed articles, including 7 in *Cities*, a journal with impact factor (IF)=8.1.

DPPA seems to acknowledge that quantity of my output is passable, but DPPA seems to have issues with quality. Again, as per

²¹News item: <https://patimes.org/from-research-to-county-strategy-how-negative-learning-shaped-camden-countys-shared-housing-innovation>

²²News item: <https://theconversation.com/abortion-laws-show-that-public-policy-doesnt-always-line-up-with-public-opinion-274699>

²³News item: <https://camden.rutgers.edu/news/rutgers-camdens-urban-innovation-fund-fuels-transformative-community-projects>

²⁴My past external funding includes the prestigious Polish National Science Foundation (PI), equivalent of the US Natl Science Foundation.

²⁵appears to be down as of May 15 2026 (as of June 2 up again), but the underlying data are at scopus.com

²⁶<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/organisations/public-policy-and-administration/persons/>

²⁷I took these from my merit pay which I wrote Nov15 2023.

²⁸<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/organisations/public-policy-and-administration/publications>

²⁹<https://www.researchwithrutgers.com/en/persons/adam-okulicz-kozaryn/publications/>

³⁰Of course, the measure is crude and simplistic as it doesn't differentiate research output's length and quality. Still, it is remarkable that over 4 years one person has produced as much as other 9 people. And on quality, too, as measured by Impact Factor of journals, there are only 2 people in the department publishing in high impact journals, I am one of them.

above, quality of the journals is outstanding as compared to the department. What I may be missing? Maybe my main research topic, happiness, doesn't fit into public policy and administration; and my papers don't discuss policy implications? Again, as I said in the main Research section in the body of the document (before this Appendix):

nothing further from the truth³¹

Or maybe my research is not causal enough? Indeed causal inference is one way to contribute—agreed; but it is only one of many ways. It's neither necessary nor sufficient for great research.

I am contributing in different ways than causality (most social science research is not causal by the way): I have novel ideas and able to find the right data to test them—I use complex large scale datasets to study new relationships—this is my contribution as recognized by my field.³²

Urbanism is my usual independent variable—it can hardly be studied in a causal way, it is an organic process in the real world—almost all research in this area, my area of research, is not causal. Economists also have it wrong that complex stats and econometrics and instrumental variables etc give you causality—no they don't! They just get you little closer if done right, but the only way to claim causality is experiments (or sometimes quasi-experiments). Causality is not about stats or models, it is about research design. So if you want to do causality right in my area of effect of cities on happiness, you would have to assign people at random to cities and rural areas—it's impossible.³³

Still, some of my research argues that the causality may be present. (But again it is impossible to know for sure without (quasi-) experiment that is not feasible in my area.) Instead, I argue directional relationship, or possibility of causality if you will, by paying attention to control variables and avoiding overcontrol bias (Golden et al. 2026), using fixed effects (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Mazelis 2018) and even before-after comparison group design (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2026).

5.1.2 Scientometrics

As per Google Scholar³⁴: I have more than doubled my citations since 2017, when I have submitted my materials for promotion to associate professor with tenure, from 163 to 353 in 2025.

According to Scopus³⁵: I have had about 4 indexed publications per year since 2017, and also my citations more than doubled between 2017 and 2025.

According to <https://adscientificindex.com> I am within the top 10% of RU scientists (220/2,364) on H-Index (Recent).³⁶

My citations on Google Scholar after having stalled for 5 years are set to increase from 350 in 2025 to over 400 in 2026: On April 28 2026, I'm cited at 143, it's 118th day of the year, so I have $143/118 = 1.2$ citations per day; $1.2 * 365 > 400$. There is even greater percentage increase on Scopus.³⁷

³¹See Diener (2009) and my own Okulicz-Kozaryn (2016). Likewise, there are clear policy implications of my work, for instance see (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015a, Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2014, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Golden 2017). My numerous Cities papers have dedicated takeaways for policy/practice section, e.g., see recent (Mikhaeil et al. 2024, Deb and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2022), and even if the section is missing, there are still policy implications, e.g., Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021).

³²By the way, some of the greatest research out there in the very top journals like Nature or Science is not causal—it's just a data visualization like a scatterplot, and yet it is the top of the top, cream of the crop research, that beats any other research causal or not. And this very top research in Nature or Science—what makes it the very top is the research idea and the right data, not causality—this is what I aspire to, and this is my research strength and direction—novel ground breaking research ideas and great data without causality.

³³I have recently reviewed a paper for a journal doing an experiment with urbanism. Urban-rural dichotomy was induced in participants experimentally with urban-rural imaginary. So yes, experiments in are possible for urbanism, but in a lab only. This is a lab setting, experimental psychology, not my area of survey research in the real world with people actually living in urban v rural areas.

³⁴https://scholar.google.com/citations?hl=en&user=pz9RYloAAAAJ&view_op=list_works&sortby=pubdate

³⁵<https://www.scopus.com/authid/detail.uri?authorId=23061538900>

³⁶<https://adscientificindex.com/scientist/adam-okulicz-kozaryn/1552726/>

³⁷Scopus: <https://www.scopus.com/authid/detail.uri?authorId=23061538900>; and Google Scholar: scholar.google.com/citations?hl=en&user=pz9RYloAAAAJ.

5.1.3 Notes/Endnotes

It was already indicated on my CV (also sent to external reviewers): note: this book is excluded from the promotion packet (this is a popular science book): Happiness and Place: Cities v Nature. Why Life is Better Outside of the City? Palgrave Macmillan.

I am collegial and collaborative—I've coauthored with over 20 authors (Scopus): <https://www.scopus.com/authid/detail.uri?authorId=23061538900#tab=co-authors>

5.2 Teaching

5.2.1 Teaching in DPPA

I mostly teach data science courses—there is departmental friction—my department doesn't want me to teach data science and prevention science students. One reason may be departmental politics. Another reason is a claim that computer coding (Python) in data science may be inaccessible to some of the DPPA students. The good news now for even most coding-averse DPPA students is AI that can write the code for them, so it should be all fixed (as of 2025 seems to be great), but let's revisit in some time what's best for students.

I can make the case that data science (and Python, not Qgis or Stata) is the future and benefits our students.³⁸ We would be doing disservice to our students not teaching them the latest and the greatest tools, and instead of sticking with dinosaurs such as SAS and SPSS. As always open to discussion here—but let's be constructive: I would like to hear your arguments against Python—why we should not use it, and use outdated tools instead? An occasional cherry-picked comment by a student is not a reasonable argument, I was getting those with legacy tools as well, and vast majority of students are happy with Python.

Sometimes, the department chair Patrice would cherry pick couple negative student evaluations out of mostly positive ones. In general student criticism falls in one of the 2 categories: Python v traditional point-and-click software like SPSS (again, it should have been resolved now with AI); and second category was clarity and organization of syllabus—"was" because I have fixed it long time ago.³⁹ Still, Patrice gives me the same criticism as recent as May 2026—I have directed Patrice to my syllabi and asked her to point out what exactly she means. When I hear back, I'll fix if there is anything to fix. So to summarize, I did take student comments into account right away long time ago when I saw these comments when they were posted. I do take teaching seriously. Keeping on bringing up things that have been fixed years ago is not helpful. The feedback from DPPA is unhelpful in other ways, too. For instance, see Paul Jargowsky class visitation section and my response to it.

Then there is also departmental friction with Prevention Science program, which just like Data Science program is outside of my home department, DPPA. I am on one dissertation committee and chairing one dissertation there—but department chair Patrice tells me I should not be doing that.

Research first: I spent most time on research, and I want to be great researcher; but I also want to be a great teacher, not just average. I am dedicated to teaching. My main effort is two-folded. First, I educate myself: I quite regularly read on teaching and mentoring advice, tips and tricks on nature.com, chronicle.com, and insidehighered.com.

TODO/MAYBE list some specific papers from eib, also srch for tag 'edu'

Second, I have an elaborate system for improvement. elaborate like a whole paragraph on my n.org system: log, todo, later/maybe!!!!

³⁸Here is an accessible read: <https://www.theatlantic.com/science/archive/2018/04/the-scientific-paper-is-obsolete/556676>

³⁹I think in particular students couldn't count 1 week, 2 weeks, or 3 weeks time—I'd post assignment and say it's due in 1, 2, or 3 weeks from the date it was posted. I personally think it's super clear, but sure, student opinion is what matters when it comes to clarity of assignments, so now I put the exact date, say Apr1, and I also put it on canvass calendar, not just on assignment. In addition I elaborate on assignment instructions with detailed footnotes to provide yet more clarity—all of that has been fixed couple years ago.

I revise, update, upgrade, extend, etc the teaching materials frequently—for instance my visualization class has been updated 200 times over past 3 years as seen from GIT commits: <https://github.com/theaok/vis/commits/main/> (of course, most updates were minor, but still 200 updates means quite continuous work on the class).

i ask students for their interests in first class, i make notes and customize each edition of the class to the specific cohort—the changes each year are not dramatic, mostly related to examples i give in class and data, often student interests are similar over years—for instance south jersey and philadelphia and social problems such as poverty

i work with students outside of the classroom; sometimes i have a quick “lab” before or after class time, when i come and/or leave early/late, but the main tool is a listserv, where we have class related conversations outside of the class; this is especially useful in coding classes where questions come up as students work on problem sets—then instead of one-on-one q and a (i do these too) we have a listserv discussion—i have learned over the years that it works better—students tend to have similar questions; and importantly some students also have answers—this works much better on a listserv forum than in one-on-one discussions; discussions are not only about problem sets but also about extra topics and tools not covered in class; i tried discussions on canvass but they don't work well, students tend to be less present, instead i use a proper listserve groups.google.com where discussions are delivered straight to a student email, i learned this approach when i took gary king's methods class at harvard

TODO do make sure class syllabi are top top notch all of them listed on my website!!! print out polish etc

TODO!!! spend a bunch of time here—was big long part of patrice writeup

and i guess in general put here on how much i care about teaching etc etc, beef it up, at the time when i think about teaching portfolio (<https://otear.rutgers.edu/teaching/teaching-portfolios/>)—it would go in this doc almost for sure, maybe even in this section here

just goog/ai how to argue teachingexcellence

40

5.2.2 Letters from students

One highlight is that the skills learned in the classes work in the real world: “The classes I took with you are helping not only my scholarship, but my day job. Thank you [...] I greatly appreciate it.” and “subject:Received a Job Offer [...] I would like to thank you for all of the guidance and knowledge during all of your data-related courses the past several semesters to help me get to the point I am at today.” and “since graduating I have continued to pursue more projects in the coding world. Some analysis projects, business models, and even some fun web apps and game designs. I appreciate all the help and motivation you gave me in class as it helped me to really see what I can come up with from all of the useful tools, how to plan and build on projects, and skills gained from having you as my professor.”

And they work in academia, and students appreciate my approach and style: “I am reaching out to explore the possibility of having you as my graduate advisor. My experience in your Data Management course left a lasting impression on me and I appreciated your approach and teaching style. I believe your guidance would be invaluable in helping me navigate the academic journey towards finishing my doctoral degree.” and “This is Teacher Appreciation Week and I just wanted to take a moment to say thank you for all the hard work and dedication you put into teaching. Your passion for education has inspired and impacted me in so many ways. Your commitment to helping your students grow and learn is truly admirable. Thank you for all that you do!” and “Please know that I deeply appreciate everything you have done for me, and I recognize the many ways you have helped me grow as a scholar and, frankly, as an agentic person in general. I am truly grateful for you.”

And my classes might have even contributed to retention in the program: ““I have learnt so much about my region is really unbelievable and I have enjoyed working with you a lot. So much, I am actually considering STAYING in the program because of you!”

⁴⁰In general, methods classes often receive lower evaluations.

""It was not an easy period for me, but your belief in me made a significant difference in helping me see it through. I recall one of your emails when you wrote, "...you have a passion for this, pursue it." That statement has stayed with me. It reflected a genuine interest in my success, and I hope I am able to pay it forward."

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Apr 15, 2026, 10:19
subject: Re: Request to pay open access APC from prof okulicz-kozaryn [260318-025834]

[...]Reflecting on this journey now, I just want to say that it was a great pleasure to work with you and to meet you Dr.Adam. But in this digital world, we will continue to communicate for sure and maybe do more work together in the future.

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Apr 23, 2026, 10:07
subject: Re: grant opportunity
mailed-by:

Dear Dr. Adam,

I hope you are doing well.

I wanted to take a moment to sincerely appreciate you for your support throughout my master's program. It was not an easy period for me, but your belief in me

I also wanted to share that I was selected as a finalist for the PhD in Global Urban Studies at Rutgers Newark, and I completed the interview process. However,

So you will definitely be seeing me again. :)

Thank you again for everything you've done to support me. I truly value your guidance

Warm regards

From:
Sent: Wednesday, April 8, 2026 12:19 AM
To: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <ao264@camden.rutgers.edu>
Subject: Fw: SEVIS Data Pull 4/6/2026 - Fall 2026

Dr. Adam,

I would be remiss if I didn't share that my day job includes working in Python all the time. The Director of the Office of International Students sends an Excel file each week that is essentially a data dump, and I've used all three of the classes I took with you to make sense of it each time. Without what I learned in your classes, it would just be a random Excel file - and I like Excel. This is just a small piece of it - I was emailing late into the night with her about ban lists and communication strategy, and that entire conversation would not have been possible without the visualizations.

I also create the attached HTML, which I share each week with my colleagues, and we've been relying on it for real decision-making. The HTML is about 85% for me - I regularly echo your point about adding notes to the data. That's what people talk about more than the visuals. They look at the charts, but they look forward to my notes.

I really appreciate everything I learned in your classes and your guidance in both my professional and academic work.

From:
Sent: Wednesday, January 21, 2026 11:21 AM
The classes I took with you are helping not only my scholarship, but my day job. Thank you.
Again, thank you for sharing your knowledge and mentorship. I greatly appreciate it.

indep stu dec18 2025
Hi Professor,

I really appreciate it! Thank you so much!

Again, I am truly grateful to have been a student of yours and learn so much from you.

Have an amazing holiday!

J

2024-04-26 Fri gmail "Dissertation development credit issue and thank you"
Also - thank you. I realize that I have spent so much time this semester focusing on what I needed to do that I neglected to ever tell you how grateful I have been for our work together. I know that I can be a real pain in the ass, and you have definitely experienced that more than anyone else at Rutgers - six credits of courses with me and chairing my dissertation committee! Please know that I deeply appreciate everything you have done for me, and I recognize the many ways you have helped me grow as a scholar and, frankly, as an agentic person in general. I am truly grateful for you.

<2024-04-21 Sun> gmail: class "Completed sections"

"I have learnt so much about my region is really unbelievable and I have enjoyed working with you a lot. So much, I am actually considering STAYING in the program because of you!"

sp22 swb May 12 at 15:30pm

Hi, Dr. Adam. Here are the materials of my final work. I follow the instructions of JPAM style. The word document may not be as neat as the PDF one due to some technical issues. I am excited that it is my first quantitative paper, although there is still a long way from publication. Thank you so much for your help! Your classes have improved me a lot. I had never thought about being able to use these knowledges before taking your classes. Thank you!

Besides, could we keep working on this paper during this summer? It will be my great honor to make a publication with you.

from:
to:Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date:Jun 25, 2018, 8:26 PM
subject:Received a Job Offer

Dr. Okulicz-Kozaryn,

I would like to thank you for all of the guidance and knowledge during all of your data-related courses the past several semesters to help me get to the point I am at today.

I was extended an offer with the Philadelphia School District as a Strategy Analyst with their Charter School Office. The office itself oversees Philadelphia's 84 charter schools (and 70k+ students). I will be doing a lot with the student level data in regard to performance/monitoring and helping with policy/research.

Thanks Again.

from:
to: "adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com" <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Oct 17, 2023
subject: Graduate Advisor Inquiry
mailed-by: em.rutgers.edu

Good Afternoon Professor Adam,

I hope this email finds you well! My name is xxx and I had the privilege of taking your Data Management course during the spring 2022 semester. I am currently enrolled in Rutgers-Camden's new PhD program in Prevention Science. I am reaching out to explore the possibility of having you as my graduate advisor. My experience in your Data Management course left a lasting impression on me and I appreciated your approach and teaching style. I believe your guidance would be invaluable in helping me navigate the academic journey towards finishing my doctoral degree. I am a part-time student with an expected completion date during the fall 2026 semester. My preliminary dissertation topic is research around the causal effects of a need-based aid program at Rutgers-New Brunswick using a quasi-experimental design such as regression discontinuity.

Please let me know if you prefer to discuss this over a Zoom call.

Best,

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: May 8, 2025
subject: Re: independent study

Hello Professor Okulicz-Kozaryn,

I have updated my github not only with my up to date notebook like I mentioned yesterday but I also uploaded this txt file as a writeup like you requested: <https://github.com/>

If there is anything else you need from me, please let me know regarding the Independent Study.

I also want to say I am very happy to have taken your classes and had you to work with for this Independent study. I want to say the knowledge that you have helped me obtain along with the projects created are very much so appreciated.

I plan not only to continue research for this topic relating to music and spotify, but I am also going to take these concepts and principles for designing and working on projects with some other future endeavors as well.

And if you ever want to contact me for the future for any projects or know of any good opportunities for work or any other connections within the data science community you can contact me at:

I hope you have a good rest of your year and you enjoy your summer!

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Jan 25, 2026
subject: Re: independent study

Hello Professor Okulicz-Kozaryn,

This was an interesting read, I agree, it seems to be a similar idea to that one project I did for your class. Thanks for sending this along to me!

I may take some inspiration from this and add on to that previous project for continuing music analysis trends in the real world.

Also, I want to share that since graduating I have continued to pursue more projects in the coding world. Some analysis projects, business models, and even some fun web apps and game designs. I appreciate all the help and motivation you gave me in class as it helped me to really see what I can come up with from all of the useful tools, how to plan and build on projects, and skills gained from having you as my professor.

Thanks and hope all is well with you!

from:
to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
cc:
date: Dec 25, 2025
subject: Christmas Greetings
mailed-by: icloud.com

Hi Prof. Adam,

Wishing you a very Merry Christmas and a joyful holiday season. I hope you're enjoying a restful break and some well-deserved time.

I've been thinking back on my time in the PhD program and remain very grateful for your guidance and support along the way. I hope the new year brings you good health, energy, and many exciting moments ahead.

Warm holiday wishes,

from:
to: adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com
date: Nov 28, 2024
subject: Inquiry about Data Management Course
mailed-by: scarletmail.rutgers.edu

Hello Professor,

I hope this email finds you well. Happy Thanksgiving!

I am writing this email after seeing the Data Management course you will be teaching in Spring 2025. If possible, I would like to know more about the course curriculum. The subject is an area of interest for me, and I am enthusiastic about enrolling in the course. I have thoroughly enjoyed being in your GIS class and I look forward to learning more under your guidance.

Thank you for your time and consideration.

Regards,

from:
to: Kelly Esterly <kelly.esterly@rutgers.edu>,
Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: Aug 5, 2025
subject: Capstone Project
mailed-by: scarletmail.rutgers.edu

Hello Prof. Adam,

I hope this email finds you well. I am reaching out to you for your guidance on my Capstone project in Fall '25. It was a great learning experience to take your classes. I look forward to working under your mentorship.

I am also having @Kelly Esterly on loop so she could issue the special code for the course

Looking forward to hearing from you. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Warm Regards,

from:
to: adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com
date: Oct 19, 2023
subject: Research opportunity Enquiry
mailed-by: scarletmail.rutgers.edu

Hello Professor ,

I'm xxx and I'm currently in your GIS class .It is great learning from you and I have been really enjoying studying subject.

I was wondering if there is any research /project opportunity to work with you ?
Is it possible to come visit you to talk regarding this at your convenience?

Thank you in advance
Regards ,

to: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn <adam.okulicz.kozaryn@gmail.com>
date: May 2, 2023
subject: Thank you
mailed-by: gmail.com

Hi Dr. Adam,
This is Teacher Appreciation Week and I just wanted to take a moment to say thank you for all the hard work and dedication you put into teaching. Your passion for education has inspired and impacted me in so many ways. Your commitment to helping your students grow and learn is truly admirable. Thank you for all that you do!

Respectfully,

5.2.3 Student evaluations—explaining few courses with lower evaluations

Looking at recent years 2022-2026: courses are at or above the department mean, with these exceptions:

-
- Fall 2025 56:824:721 Community Well-Being—this deserves a subsection on its own—see below.
- Fall 2024 56:834:535 Research Methods—a required statistics course—these tend to get lower evaluations in general. 3.29/3.43—to be sure scores that are not great, but have improved slightly from earlier: Fall 2021 3.36/3.00 and Fall 2020 3.22/3.22 and have improved greatly versus before my promotion with tenure in 2018 (not shown in current form 1a): Fall 2017 2.70/2.60.
- Fall 2023 56:824:718/56:834:650/56:219:522 Data Management: 3.33/3.33 are actually not far from data science departmental mean at the time: 3.79/3.78—the Data Science Program has just launched and these courses were just newly developed for the program. By 2025 my evaluations went up to 4.60/4.40
- Spring 2023 56:824:728:40/56:834:653:40/56:219:521:40 Data Visualization: same thing as in the previous item.

To reiterate, and few other things to note per recent years 2022-2026. Recent course evaluations tend to be around department mean. Specifically, while my recent data science courses tend to be at or above the department mean, the 56:834:535 Research Methods course tend to be below⁴¹ Another pattern to note is that over years the teaching evaluations have gone up versus earlier years. One reason is that I have developed earlier brand new courses for brand new program MS in Data Science and it was the first time I was teaching those.

Earlier years 2018-2021. Low evaluations for 2018 56:834:535:A1 Research Methods—it was online class—during the summer—my mother passed away during that summer. And the only other course with lower evaluations than the above mentioned was Fall 2020 56:824:725, 56:834:608 GIS Public Sector at 3.29/3.30—to be honest I do not remember well that course and I am not sure what the explanation could be here—I might have experimented with new approaches.

Fall 2025 56:824:721:40 Community Well-Being it had only 3 students, 2 students gave 5, one student gave 1

⁴¹here that footnote that required stats courses tend to get lower eval that i already have it dangling somewhere.

address low swb class eval bc on angela like cp paste all verbal stuff from 3 students incl 2 paraguay, and from my response to patrice; and see notes in n.org in tenure/assoc-to-full

and add her transcript: keeps on getting Cs, not just me having issues with her

5.2.4 Paul Jargowsky class visitation, and my response

Rutgers University-Camden
Department of Public Policy and Administration
Faculty Peer Evaluation of Classroom Teaching

Course:

- 56:219:521 DATA VISUALIZATION (dat sci)
- 56:824:728 DATA VISUALIZATION (soc sci/pub pol)
- 56:834:653 DATA VISUALIZATION (soc sci/pub pol)

Instructor: Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn **Date Evaluated:** April 3, 2025

Note: Given the long time elapsed since the class observation, I supplemented my notes by watching the class video.

1. Subject of Class:

1) visualization techniques for data clustering, e.g. dendrograms and k-means scatterplots, 2) annotation of graphs using matplotlib, 3) “flipped classroom” to respond to student questions about a problem set.

2. Relevance of the subject to the course:

The content was appropriate to a course on data visualization, touching on important methods for representing clusters and relationships in data.

3. A. Was an assignment made: Yes _____ No ☒

Although no new assignment was introduced during the session, students appeared engaged with an assignment from the prior week and came prepared to discuss it.

B. Were students prepared: Yes ☒ No _____

4. Clarity of the ideas presented:

The description of the class as given to the students:

[apr3] clustering

a bit similar to previous scatterplots; clustering is about grouping / finding patterns, and very much data sciency!

we only scratch the surface here--just few popular vis for clustering;
i don't cover here the method, algorithms etc

Adam worked systematically through the material, alternating between code demonstrations in an online notebook and examples. The examples were presented clearly, but the presentation would have benefited from stronger substantive and conceptual framing. For example, the class could have explored more explicitly when to use a dendrogram versus a scatterplot with k-means clustering. For another, an “elbow plot” was presented as diagnostic for k-means clustering, but there was no explanation of what the plot represented, only that it tells you then ideal number of groups (based on what?). Without more grounding, the different types of visualizations are just black boxes.

While links to more in-depth discussion of the visualizations in relevant textbooks were provided, they lacked specific guidance (e.g., chapters or sections), which may make it difficult for students to locate the relevant material.

5. Manner of delivery:

Adam put students at ease and was very responsive to student questions. He made good use of examples, both simple examples using a small dataset followed by more complete examples using graphics from published papers.

6. Effective use of teaching aide(s), if they apply:

Rather than a whiteboard or PowerPoint slides, Adam used an online coding notebook, an environment for writing and executing code. This is an appropriate format given the material and the emphasis on coding. However, the notebook’s structure—one long, cumulative document covering several classes—made it difficult to follow at times, as his frequent scrolling up and down through the long document disrupted the flow. Segmenting the material into separate notebooks for each class or adding clearer section headings could improve clarity and pacing.

7. Student participation: The students were engaged throughout and asked appropriate questions. Adam had a good rapport with the students. When students sought deeper conceptual explanations (e.g., how clustering algorithms work), the responses could have gone beyond general descriptions to help students better understand the mechanics and assumptions of these techniques.

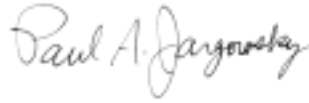
8: Other comments:

The syllabus and class notes would benefit from more careful organization and editing. Clearer structure, proofreading, and a consistent format would strengthen the professional presentation of the course materials and better reflect the high standards of our program.

More broadly, the course could be enhanced by integrating theoretical and design-oriented perspectives on data visualization—topics such as perception, cognition, and design principles. These form the intellectual foundation of the field and help students make informed decisions about how to represent data effectively and truthfully.

Adam’s course provides strong coding content and fosters an open, interactive learning

environment. The main opportunities for improvement lie in strengthening conceptual foundations, improving the organization and clarity of course materials, and ensuring that design and communication principles are integrated alongside technical skills. These adjustments would make the class more rigorous and balanced, aligning it more closely with the best practices in data visualization pedagogy. Without that, students may learn *how* to make various chart but not *why* certain choices communicate data more truthfully or effectively.



Visitor: _____

Date: 11/11/2025 Instructor:  Date: nov21 2025

Acceptance or comments:

The evaluation was helpful as it made me realize that my html bullet points didn't render and thus obscured readability; and it got me thinking about spending less time on code as AI takes over. Other than that the evaluation was unhelpful. I would like to raise several issues so that we can do better in the future.

Paul does not teach Python or data visualization. Neither does he use Python in his research. I was arguing to have someone else evaluate my teaching. I even found a replacement to do evaluation. Then I can't get the evaluation for 7 months (class was in April, I get evaluation in November) despite multiple emails and reminders. And then evaluation is mostly unhelpful as outlined below with my inline responses.

"the presentation would have benefited from stronger substantive and conceptual framing. "

It's a data visualization class, not math or algorithms class.

"an "elbow plot" was presented as diagnostic for k-means clustering, but there was no explanation of what the plot represented, only that it tells you then ideal number of groups (based on what?). Without more grounding, the different types of visualizations are just black boxes."

That's the whole point of the "elbow plot" to tell the number of groups. Again, it's a data visualization class, not math or algorithms class.

"While links to more in-depth discussion of the visualizations in relevant textbooks were provided, they lacked specific guidance (e.g., chapters or sections), which may make it difficult for students to locate the relevant material."

No. There is a reference to a specific chapter: "and especially machine learning ch: <https://jakevdp.github.io/PythonDataScienceHandbook/05.00-machine-learning.html>"

"the notebook's structure—one long, cumulative document covering several classes—made it difficult to follow at times, as his frequent scrolling up and down through the long document disrupted the flow. Segmenting the

material into separate notebooks for each class or adding clearer section headings could improve clarity and pacing."

There are not only section headings, but there are 3 levels of them: chapters, sections, and sub-sections (and I even police this in students' assignments—I take points off if students don't use sections).

"Clearer structure, proofreading, and a consistent format would strengthen the professional presentation of the course materials and better reflect the high standards of our program."

I was trying to discuss and get a sense of what Paul means here but I wasn't able to get detailed or specific information. As far as I can tell it's about writing style: Paul is traditional and formal. And I'm quite the opposite: modern, straightforward, and informal.

My materials have a clear structure and consistent format. I actually have a specific philosophy here to be straightforward and informal. I follow Zinnser's "On Writing Well: The Essential Guide to Mastering Nonfiction Writing and Effective Communication." For instance: "Never say anything in writing that you wouldn't comfortably say in conversation. If you're not a person who says "indeed" or "moreover," or who calls someone an individual ("he's a fine individual"), please don't write it." I was asking Paul for reference to his style, but I didn't get any.

I even wrote a paper on cluttered and ornamented grandiose prose in social science as compared to natural science: <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11192-012-0937-9>

So called social science "professional presentation" in writing can typically actually obscure meaning and communication. Again, following Zinnser, the goal should be simplicity and readability.

Per "high standards of our program"--i think my teaching has a good standard, e.g., my current students publish in good journals: https://theaok.github.io/okulicz_kozaryn_cv.pdf#page=6

And, what do we mean by "high standards of our program"? Is it formal traditional writing? Does such writing translate into desired outcomes, i.e. communication and learning? (especially in methods/coding classes). These are ever more relevant questions as we are increasingly over-burdened by information. Clarity, simplicity, and readability seem a way to go.

"More broadly, the course could be enhanced by integrating theoretical and design-oriented perspectives on data visualization—topics such as perception, cognition, and design principles. These form the intellectual foundation of the field and help students make informed decisions about how to represent data effectively and truthfully. Adam's course provides strong coding content and fosters an open, interactive learning environment. The main opportunities for improvement lie in strengthening conceptual foundations, improving the organization and clarity of course materials, and ensuring that design and communication principles are integrated alongside technical skills. These adjustments would make the class more rigorous and balanced, aligning it more closely with the best practices in data visualization pedagogy. Without that, students may learn how to make various chart but not why certain choices communicate data more truthfully or effectively."

These were covered in the course earlier. The class was geared towards the students, not towards the visitation, i.e. the visited Apr3 class was not self-contained, it did not include important elements included in other classes.

I did reach out to Paul to discuss, build bridges, and understand each other better. We had 2 discussions, somewhat helpful, but still I was not able to get enough details and specificity. I got a sense that it is time to wrap up, hence my lengthy response above. For the future, I am hoping we can agree to disagree and work out constructive compromises.

The evaluation was also helpful in a sense that I watched the class video and noted I could have had a little more eye contact and walk around more and be less on the monitor. But again as outlined above most of the evaluation is unhelpful--I hope in the future we can be more constructive. I am excited to discuss and collaborate on teaching. I think we could focus more on teaching.

Rev. 1/12

5.3 Service

Service to the field is especially reviewing for journals: journals and counts are in the CV on p. 4: https://theaok.github.io/okulicz_kozaryn_cv.pdf#page=4, and co-editing Social Indicators Research journal.

Service to students is especially co-authoring journal articles, chairing dissertations and doing independent studies—again details and counts are in CV.

5.3.1 Service for DPPA

I see myself as research leader in the department—and I also perform research-related service: I'm not only productive in research myself but also lead students—over past 6 years published 10 papers with students including 3 in high impact Cities—I involve students in reviewing papers for Social Indicators Research that I co-edit, I mentored 2 students to publish in Social Indicators Research—I think we could capitalize even more⁴² on my research strengths. We have graduate students, and especially PhDs—to be able to teach and mentor them to be researchers we faculty really need to do research ourselves in the first place.

DPPA is a difficult department and there is a great deal of departmental politics that I try to stay out of.⁴³ At the same time, I'd say I am collegial. Up until this point, for the 14 years that I have been in DPPA, I have never refused any service—I think that such full unconditional openness to departmental service is at least above average if not outstanding.

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I go above and beyond on dissertation supervision. I supervise 5. The departmental recommendation is 3. In addition, I am supervising master theses in data science (I don't think anyone in DPPA supervises master theses), and I do many independent studies—in fact I think I'm doing more than anybody else in the department here. Over past 6 years 2020-2026, supervised 9 dissertations (4 graduated; 5 in-progress), served on 6 dissertation committees, supervised 6 data science master theses, served on 2 master thesis committees in other social sciences, and supervised 15 independent studies. Again, there may be some cross-departmental friction and politics and DPPA may say that we don't need independent studies and master theses in data science. Still, the dissertations are almost exclusively DPPA, and there is a good number of DPPA independent studies.

The department chair, Patrice, seems to miss that I already have been doing these, and still keeps on asking for:

- “data dashboards.” I did: <https://chedvi.onrender.com/>, and <https://maps-dppa.camden.rutgers.edu/index.php?search=map&title=Special%3ASearch&profile=default&fulltext=1> (available on campus or via RU VPN only)
- “assisting affiliated centers with data.” Done that too: professional services and data analysis for Community Leadership Center (CLC) 2018; Geographic Information System (GIS) workshop for The Walter Rand Institute for Public Affairs (WRI) <https://theaok.github.io/shortGIS/vShortGeoda.pdf> 2019; supervised public affairs PhD Zach Chengcheng Yue at WRI: Covid-19 in Atlantic County Spring-Fall 2025; supervised public affairs PhD Marlo Rossi at WRI: Abortion in South Jersey Fall 2025-Spring 2026. I can do more here and on regular basis, but of course need grants or consulting fees. I am happy to discount my rate for scientific/non-activist projects.

⁴²For instance I could take students to ISQOLS conference, and I could be a program director for the PhD program.

⁴³I was thinking that staying out of the departmental politics is a virtue. But maybe it is a vice? Maybe that's why my department is saying that I could be more collegial? Again, I was doing all assigned service, but for some reason it appears it is not enough.

⁴⁴Paul was not happy with my service on his PhD/methods committee and kicked me out of the committee. This is not refusing service—I did my service, Paul didn't like it, so that's fine we have a difference of opinion—but still, I was doing the service I was asked to do. Paul may say I wasn't putting enough effort—I'd say I was productive and efficient. Planning for the future: Patrice says I should keep on chairing Events/Awards committee. The only 2 productive things I was doing on that committee was regular monthly or bi-monthly brown-bag seminars and an annual or so workshop (publishing, GIS, etc)—I volunteer to keep on doing those. Other things, I have nothing to do with: awards and end-of-year ceremony are 100% handled by Patrice, Mike, and Lisa, and I have 0 input there. Likewise, faculty mixer. Bailey lecture—I was hoping to have some input there, but my speaker proposals are routinely turned down. UAA pre-presentations—I have no idea about that conference; I offered to do ISQOLS pre-presentations, but Patrice wants to keep UAA, so whoever mentors students in that direction is best fit for that (if such person exists). Again, I am not refusing service, just being productive/efficient.

- “data mentoring”—I don’t think I could do more here⁴⁵
- being collegial and collaborative. I am! I have a warm, friendly and happy disposition (I study happiness after all)—I think I am the happiest and most social person in DPPA actually.⁴⁶ I have served on departmental committees (again, I did all the service I was asked for): Awards/Events 2012-25, Strategic Planning 2019-20, PR/Website 2012-16, PhD committee 2014-21, and Methods Qualifying Exam 2012-21. I offer folks help with data. I organize workshops (see CV for details): GIS workshops, brown bags, howto publish, and collaborated on a grant recently in the department.

Again, I want to highlight that I did all the service I was asked to do for the department. And I want to point out that DPPA could use some more democracy and shared governance. Let’s have more democracy, where non-full professors’ voices are heard. Let’s make sure people can grow, and pursue their own path.

We have these rigid structures both historical and current. Historical: someone decided probably 20-50 years ago we need certain class in core as requirement such as regional economic development, the person teaching that is long gone, the requirement still exists. Current: we have very rigid military-like structure with top-down decision making. Let’s get rid of that and have democracy and capitalize on people’s strengths and individual paths.⁴⁷

And again, as stated at in the “Background” section at the beginning, I cannot overemphasize this enough: Rutgers-Camden is R-2 High Research Activity institution—we should be mostly about research, say about 60% research, 25% teaching, 15% service, but DPPA is quite the opposite: 60% activism/civic engagement/service, 20% teaching, and 20% research.⁴⁸

⁴⁵Again, Over past 6 years 2020-2026, supervised 9 dissertations (4 graduated; 5 in-progress), served on 6 dissertation committees, supervised 6 data science master theses, served on 2 master thesis committees in other social sciences, and supervised 15 independent studies.

⁴⁶Not a great achievement as the bar is low—DPPA does seem even less social and less happy than highly asocial and relatively unhappy US (Putnam 2001, Okulicz-Kozaryn and Martinez 2025). I am thinking to do a study of emotions from facial expressions during our faculty meetings.

⁴⁷For instance, let’s capitalize on my data science strength in teaching—we already started doing that and let’s continue. I’m better fit to teach data science than regional economic development or quantitative methods that should be modernized and redesigned towards data science. Again, I can make the case that data science (and Python, not Qgis or Stata) is the future and benefits our students. I am mindful of the fact that occasionally a DPPA student has struggled in the past, but now with AI that should not be a problem anymore. But again, as always happy to have a discussion here.

⁴⁸This is even more problematic when there are graduate students especially PhDs, as it is the case in DPPA—how can we teach and mentor them to do research, if we don’t do research ourselves?